

**Promotion And Preservation Of The Ijaw Culture Through Jide Jblaze Oyegbile's
*Stitches***

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ABSTRACT

This study examines the promotion and preservation of Ijaw culture through Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches. Although previous studies have explored the role of film in preserving Nigerian cultures, limited scholarly attention has been given to how indigenous Ijaw-language films function as cultural texts that promote and preserve Ijaw cultural heritage. Addressing this gap, the study investigates how Stitches represents and transmits Ijaw cultural values, beliefs, traditions, and identity through language, religion, family structures, festivals, costumes, music, and communal life. The study adopts literary content analysis as its methodology, while Stuart Hall's Representation Theory and Edward B. Tylor's Cultural Transmission Theory provide the analytical framework. Findings reveal that Stitches effectively promotes and preserves Ijaw culture through its depiction of indigenous settings, language, music, costumes, traditional values, and cultural practices, while reinforcing cultural identity through cinematic representation. However, the sustainability and wider impact of indigenous Ijaw films are constrained by inadequate funding, weak distribution networks, poor archival and preservation practices, piracy, and limited institutional support. The study recommends increased funding, stronger anti-piracy measures, capacity-building programmes for filmmakers, and collaboration with cultural institutions and international distributors. It concludes that Stitches contributes to scholarship on African indigenous cinema by demonstrating film's role in cultural representation, transmission, and preservation.

Keywords: Cultural Promotion, Cultural Preservation, Ijaw Culture, Indigenous Film, Stitches

INTRODUCTION

Film has evolved into one of the most effective media for communicating ideas, promoting cultural values, and preserving the heritage of societies. According to David Bordwell and Kristin Thompson, film communicates ideas through moving images, sound, and narrative (3). Beyond entertainment, it educates, informs, and shapes public opinion through visual storytelling. Susan Hayward observes that cinema influences audiences' perceptions and understanding of society through its visual and narrative techniques (8). Consequently, film serves as an important medium for preserving collective memory, reinforcing social values, and transmitting cultural identity across generations.

Since its commercialization by the Lumière brothers in 1895, film has developed into a global medium of cultural expression and communication. Bordwell and Thompson note that cinema evolved from a technological innovation into one of the world's most influential cultural

institutions (5). It has become a vehicle for projecting national identities and cultural values. Andrew Higson argues that national cinema contributes significantly to the construction of national identity (36), while Ella Shohat and Robert Stam contend that cinema has historically disseminated dominant cultural ideologies across national boundaries (30). Consequently, globalization and the circulation of foreign films have contributed to cultural imperialism, often marginalizing indigenous traditions and identities. John Tomlinson argues that the global flow of media frequently promotes cultural homogenization at the expense of local cultures (2). Edward B. Tylor defines culture as "that complex whole which includes knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom, and any other capabilities and habits acquired by man as a member of society" (1), underscoring its role in sustaining a people's identity across generations.

The Ijaw people of Bayelsa State possess a rich cultural heritage expressed through their language, festivals, folklore, traditional institutions, music, dance, dress, and communal values. According to Ebiegberi Joe Alagoa, this heritage is deeply rooted in the history, traditions, and belief systems of the Ijaw people (15). However, increasing exposure to Western media and globalization has contributed to the gradual decline of indigenous cultural practices. Tomlinson notes that globalization often weakens local cultures through the widespread circulation of dominant media (9). Similarly, Stuart Hall argues that cultural identities are continually reshaped through representation (21), while Ngũgĩ wa Thiong'o maintains that the marginalization of indigenous languages contributes to cultural alienation and the erosion of collective identity (16). Consequently, traditional marriage rites, storytelling, indigenous attire, festivals, and the use of indigenous languages are becoming less prominent, particularly among younger generations.

Despite its association with cultural imperialism, film also serves as an important medium for cultural promotion and preservation. Stuart Hall argues that media representation constructs and communicates cultural meaning (15), while Manthia Diawara maintains that African cinema documents indigenous histories and identities often marginalized within dominant global media (24). Although studies on film and cultural preservation have focused largely on Nollywood, African cinema, and representation, limited attention has been paid to indigenous Ijaw-language films as sites of cultural transmission. This study addresses that gap by examining Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's *Stitches* as a cultural text through which Ijaw identity is represented and transmitted. Rather than merely demonstrating that film preserves culture, the study shows how *Stitches* employs language, costumes, music, traditional institutions, and communal practices to construct and sustain Ijaw cultural identity. In doing so, it contributes to scholarship on indigenous cinema by demonstrating the significance of Ijaw-language filmmaking as a medium for cultural representation and preservation.

LITERATURE REVIEW

Concept of Culture

Culture is one of the most contested concepts in the human sciences, encompassing the shared beliefs, values, practices, languages, rituals, and institutions through which communities organise social life. It has therefore been examined across anthropology, sociology, philosophy, literature, and cultural studies. Raymond Williams describes culture as both the ordinary and extraordinary aspects of human existence, arguing that it is embedded in everyday life and

shared meanings rather than confined to artistic achievement (3). Similarly, Roger Keesing defines culture as the complex whole of knowledge, belief, art, morals, law, custom, and other acquired capabilities of members of society (64). Beyond a collection of practices, culture functions as a symbolic system through which people construct meaning. Clifford Geertz views culture as inherited conceptions expressed through symbolic forms that shape people's understanding of life (89), while Stuart Hall argues that cultural identity is continually produced through history, representation, and power relations (225). These perspectives are particularly relevant to this study because they explain how film represents and reproduces cultural meanings rather than merely reflecting them.

Although scholars differ in emphasis, anthropological perspectives stress continuity, whereas cultural studies highlight negotiation and changing identities. Structuralist, post-structuralist, Marxist, and practice-based approaches similarly recognise culture as a site of meaning, ideology, and social practice (Eagleton 8). Contemporary scholarship further shows that globalisation and digital technologies have transformed cultural production while increasing concerns about the erosion of indigenous cultures (Arnould and Thompson 267; Couldry and Mejias 3). Within Nigeria, literature, music, and other creative arts continue to function as cultural archives. Patrick Iroegbu, Ngozi Ezeani, and Chidi Okeke demonstrate that creative works preserve history, communal values, and cultural identity. However, comparatively little attention has been given to indigenous-language cinema as a medium of cultural representation. This study addresses that gap by examining how *Stitches* represents and sustains Ijaw cultural identity through film.

Concept of Cultural Preservation

Cultural preservation refers to the safeguarding and transmission of both tangible and intangible cultural heritage for present and future generations. It extends beyond monuments to include languages, oral traditions, indigenous knowledge, festivals, rituals, and social practices. Laurajane Smith defines preservation as the identification, conservation, management, and transmission of cultural heritage to ensure continuity (22), while Lynn Meskell includes both material heritage and intangible cultural practices such as oral histories and indigenous knowledge (37). Scholars further argue that preservation promotes cultural continuity and collective well-being (Cheng Steven 105), requires community participation (Waterton and Smith 122), and is increasingly supported by digital technologies (Cameron and Kenderdine 52). Nevertheless, globalisation, urbanisation, and political instability continue to threaten indigenous cultural heritage (Labadi and Long 74).

In Nigeria, preservation efforts focus largely on indigenous languages, oral traditions, festivals, music, and folklore. Okpewho, Akinwumi, and Chuma Ezekwe emphasise these cultural expressions as repositories of indigenous heritage. However, limited scholarship examines indigenous cinema as a strategy for preserving minority cultures. This study therefore examines *Stitches* as an audiovisual medium through which Ijaw cultural heritage is represented and transmitted.

Film and Cultural Preservation

Film is increasingly recognised as an effective medium for documenting, preserving, and transmitting cultural heritage. Through images, language, music, costume, performance, and

landscape, it preserves both the tangible and intangible dimensions of culture. Consequently, African film scholars regard cinema not merely as entertainment but as a site of cultural memory and identity formation. Within Nigeria, film functions as entertainment, social commentary, and cultural documentation. As Eze Chima observes, filmmakers such as Tunde Kelani employ indigenous histories, festivals, traditional ceremonies, moral values, and social practices to preserve intangible cultural heritage (25). Similarly, *Gangs of Lagos* incorporates the Eyo masquerade into its narrative, documenting indigenous traditions while promoting cultural awareness (Akin Jimoh 25).

Beyond documentation, film constructs cultural identity. Adejunmobi Moradewun argues that Nollywood shapes national and ethnic identities through its representation of vernacular languages, local cultures, and indigenous value systems (28). This supports Stuart Hall's view that representation actively constructs cultural meaning. Indigenous-language films therefore provide minority communities with opportunities for cultural visibility and self-representation. Despite this recognition, scholarship has focused largely on mainstream Nollywood, with limited attention to indigenous-language films produced by minority ethnic groups. Consequently, less attention has been given to how cinematic elements such as language, costume, music, performance, and setting collectively represent indigenous identities and facilitate cultural transmission. This study addresses that gap by examining *Stitches* through Hall's Representation Theory and Tylor's Cultural Transmission Theory to show how the film represents and transmits Ijaw cultural heritage.

The digital revolution has further expanded the preservation potential of indigenous cinema through streaming platforms, digital archives, subtitling, and online distribution (Omoniyi 89). Thus, indigenous-language films now serve not only as cultural archives but also as important media for cultural education and identity formation. Within this context, *Stitches* demonstrates how indigenous cinema contributes to the promotion and preservation of Ijaw language, beliefs, institutions, values, and communal life.

THEORETICAL FRAMEWORK

This study is anchored on Stuart Hall's Representation Theory and Edward B. Tylor's Cultural Transmission Theory.

Representation Theory

Representation Theory is primarily associated with Stuart Hall, particularly in his work *Representation: Cultural Representations and Signifying Practices*. According to Hall, representation is the process through which meaning is produced and communicated within a culture through language, images, symbols, and signs. The theory argues that media texts, including films, do not merely reflect reality but actively construct how reality is understood by audiences. Through representation, filmmakers deliberately select cultural elements and present them in ways that influence how identities, traditions, and social realities are perceived.

Representation Theory emphasizes the role of the media in promoting cultural awareness and shaping public understanding of culture and identity. The way a people and their culture are portrayed in the media largely determines how they are perceived by both members of the society and outsiders. When indigenous languages, customs, festivals, dress, beliefs, and values

are authentically represented in films, they promote cultural appreciation, strengthen cultural identity, and encourage pride in indigenous heritage. Conversely, their absence or misrepresentation may contribute to cultural distortion, marginalization, and eventual decline.

The relevance of Representation Theory to this study lies in its ability to explain how film serves as a platform for promoting and preserving indigenous cultures. In the context of the Ijaw people of Bayelsa State, films that depict traditional festivals, marriage rites, folklore, language, indigenous music, communal values, and social institutions become cultural texts that project and celebrate Ijaw identity. Through these representations, *Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches* promotes Ijaw culture to wider audiences while preserving important aspects of the people's cultural heritage for future generations.

Cultural Transmission Theory

Cultural Transmission Theory is commonly associated with Edward B. Tylor, whose *Primitive Culture* (1871) provides one of the earliest systematic explanations of culture as a body of knowledge, beliefs, customs, and values acquired through learning and passed from one generation to another. According to Tylor, culture is not inherited biologically but is learned through social interaction and transmitted through institutions such as the family, education, religion, and the media. The theory maintains that the continuity of any society depends on the successful transmission of its cultural values, norms, beliefs, and practices across generations. Traditionally, this process occurred through oral traditions, storytelling, folklore, rituals, festivals, and communal interactions. In contemporary society, however, mass media has emerged as one of the most effective channels for transmitting cultural knowledge. Consequently, film has become an important medium for documenting, promoting, and preserving indigenous cultures while making them accessible to broader and younger audiences.

The relevance of Cultural Transmission Theory to this study lies in its explanation of how film functions as a contemporary mechanism for promoting and preserving indigenous culture. As traditional avenues of cultural transmission continue to decline due to globalization and increasing Western influence, culturally grounded films provide an alternative means of safeguarding cultural heritage. Through the production and circulation of films such as *Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches*, important aspects of Ijaw culture-including language, traditional leadership, festivals, folklore, indigenous music, marriage customs, and communal values-are documented, promoted, and transmitted to present and future generations.

METHODOLOGY

This study adopts literary content analysis to examine how *Stitches* represents and transmits Ijaw cultural heritage. The primary data are derived from *Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches*, while the secondary data consist of academic journals, textbooks, newspapers, magazines, conference papers, and other relevant publications on film, culture, and indigenous communication. Literary content analysis was selected because it facilitates a systematic qualitative interpretation of narrative, dialogue, characters, symbols, costume, setting, language, music, and other cinematic elements through which cultural meanings are communicated. Unlike approaches that focus primarily on audience reception or visual style, this method is appropriate

because it enables the examination of both narrative content and cultural representation.

The film was viewed repeatedly, and scenes relevant to the study's objectives were purposively selected for analysis. Interpretation was guided by thematic categories, including language, religion, family, marriage, festivals, traditional institutions, music, costume, communal values, and other cultural practices represented in the film. These categories served as the analytical framework for interpreting how *Stitches* promotes and preserves Ijaw cultural identity. The selected scenes were analysed using Stuart Hall's Representation Theory and Edward B. Tylor's Cultural Transmission Theory to explain how the film constructs cultural meanings and functions as a medium for transmitting Ijaw cultural heritage. Secondary sources provided the theoretical and empirical basis for interpreting the findings and situating them within existing scholarship.

Overall, literary content analysis enables *Stitches* to be examined not merely as entertainment but as a cultural text that documents, represents, and transmits the traditions, values, and lived experiences of the Ijaw people.

DATA PRESENTATION

Background of the Ijaw People

The Ijaw are one of the largest ethnic groups in Nigeria's Niger Delta, with a history closely linked to the region's cultural, environmental, and socio-political development. They are indigenous to the riverine and coastal areas where fishing, farming, and trading traditionally sustain their livelihood, making their culture inseparable from the waterways (Ebiegberi Joe Alagoa 3). Oral traditions and archaeological evidence attest to their long history of settlement and social organisation. According to Alagoa, Ijaw society operates a decentralised system based on autonomous clans, age grades, and communal consensus (7). Their worldview is rooted in the riverine environment, where water spirits and deities influence festivals, folklore, and communal values (Victor Jike 26). Although colonialism and oil exploration altered their socio-economic life through environmental degradation and marginalisation (Okonta Ike and Oronto Douglas 89), the Ijaw have sustained their cultural identity through indigenous traditions and communal institutions.

Elements and Expressions of Ijaw Culture

Ijaw culture is expressed through language, religion, social institutions, music, festivals, food, costumes, and other cultural practices that shape communal identity.

Language and Oral Tradition

Language remains central to Ijaw identity, serving as the medium for transmitting history, moral values, customary laws, and oral traditions. Eweka Osarumwense observes that these oral forms preserve social memory and reinforce cultural norms across generations (76).

Religion and Social Organisation

Ijaw spirituality is closely connected to the riverine environment through the worship of water

spirits and other deities that shape rituals, festivals, and communal ethics (Victor Jike 26). Although Christianity has influenced religious practice, indigenous beliefs continue to coexist with it (Akpotor Omesiri 37). Social life is organised around kinship, age grades, councils of elders, and traditional institutions, with rites of passage reinforcing communal values.

Music, Festivals, and Material Culture

Music, dance, festivals, costumes, and symbolic artefacts preserve historical memory and cultural identity. Folk songs, drumming, festivals, ceremonial costumes, and traditional regalia communicate religious beliefs, social roles, and communal values while transmitting cultural knowledge across generations (Helen Akopo 93; Okon Isaac 65).

Food and Body Adornment

Traditional foods, including *onunu*, *banga* soup, fish, and other local produce, reinforce kinship and communal celebrations (Alagoa 56). Likewise, traditional attire, beads, cowrie shells, body painting, hairstyles, and other forms of adornment signify identity, status, rites of passage, and cultural affiliation (Victor Jike 89; Joseph Agbo 88).

Despite the influence of modernisation, mass media, and environmental challenges, these cultural expressions remain important markers of Ijaw identity and provide the cultural context within which *Stitches* represents and promotes Ijaw heritage.

ANALYSIS OF *STITCHES*

The film centres on Ebi-Ere, a young woman whose life is shaped by the tragic loss of her parents during childhood. The experience leaves her emotionally scarred, causing her to reject faith in God, traditional beliefs, and the customs of her ancestral home. Her life changes when she meets Douye, who introduces himself as a fellow indigene of Okoloba and persuades her to accompany him on a visit to their ancestral community. Although initially reluctant, Ebi-Ere accepts the invitation partly because it offers an opportunity to visit her grandmother, Grandma Owei. Accompanied by her close friend, Shade, she embarks on the journey.

On getting Okoloba, Ebi-Ere is confronted with the deeply rooted customs of the community. She learns about the sacred laws governing communal life, including the prohibition against women visiting the sacred river during menstruation. As her relationship with Douye develops, the elders encourage them to formalise their union according to traditional marriage rites while educating them on the cultural values of the community. Participation in the annual cultural festival further reconnects Ebi-Ere with her heritage.

The narrative reaches its climax when Ebi-Ere deliberately violates the community's sacred prohibition by entering the sacred river during her menstrual period. Her action is interpreted as a desecration of a revered cultural taboo, resulting in a mysterious illness believed to be the wrath of the gods. Although the Chief Priestess prescribes sacrifices to restore harmony, her condition remains unchanged, leaving Douye, Grandma Owei, and the community devastated. The tragic ending foregrounds the relationship between personal conviction, indigenous belief systems, and the consequences of disregarding sacred communal values.

CHARACTERS IN *STITCHES*

Ebi-Ere: Ebi-Ere, the protagonist, drives the film's central conflict. Orphaned at a young age, she grows up burdened by emotional trauma and rejects both Christianity and her cultural heritage. Independent and outspoken, she questions inherited traditions and violates the sacred prohibition against entering the river during menstruation, triggering the film's tragic climax. Through her, the film explores the consequences of personal alienation from communal values.

Douye: Douye represents the coexistence of Christianity and African traditional values. Although devoted to his Christian faith, he respects his community's customs and encourages Ebi-Ere to reconnect with her ancestral roots. His character symbolises faith, perseverance, and the harmony between religious belief and cultural identity.

Grandma Owei: Grandma Owei serves as the custodian of Okoloba's cultural heritage. She encourages Ebi-Ere to embrace her ancestry and, following the violation of the sacred taboo, supports the prescribed cleansing rites. Her character underscores the role of elders in preserving indigenous traditions.

Shade: Although not an indigene of Okoloba, Shade approaches its customs with respect and cautions Ebi-Ere against entering the sacred river. She represents cultural openness and respect for indigenous traditions.

Douye's Parents: Douye's parents uphold the customs, marriage rites, and spiritual values of the community. By supporting both the traditional marriage process and the prescribed response to Ebi-Ere's transgression, they reinforce the role of the older generation in sustaining communal identity.

LANGUAGE OF THE MOVIE

Stitches employs both English and the Ijaw language, reflecting the linguistic reality of the riverine communities of Bayelsa State. English is used mainly by younger characters such as Ebi-Ere, Douye, and Shade, while Ijaw predominates among elders during family discussions, marriage negotiations, communal meetings, festivals, and sacred rituals. This bilingual representation enhances the film's authenticity and reinforces its cultural setting. The use of Ijaw is particularly significant during rituals, warnings about the sacred river, and communal deliberations, where it conveys cultural authority and the sacredness of tradition. By preserving indigenous language within its narrative, the film reinforces Ijaw cultural identity despite the influence of modern society.

DISCUSSION

Cultural Elements Presented in Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's *Stitches*

Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's *Stitches* presents a rich representation of the cultural realities of the Niger Delta, particularly those of the Ijaw people of Bayelsa State. Through its setting, characterization, language, traditional institutions, religious beliefs, and communal interactions, the film projects indigenous cultural values while examining the relationship between modernity and tradition. Rather than presenting culture as a static phenomenon,

Stitches portrays it as a living system that regulates social relationships, moral conduct, spirituality, and communal identity.

Indigenous Religious Beliefs and Spirituality

One of the most dominant cultural elements in *Stitches* is the portrayal of indigenous religious beliefs. The people of Okoloba regard the sacred river as a spiritually significant site protected by ancestral deities. This belief system drives the narrative, as the central conflict arises from Ebi-Ere's deliberate violation of the prohibition against entering the sacred river during menstruation. Members of the community interpret her mysterious illness as the consequence of offending the gods rather than an ordinary medical condition. The consultation of the Chief Priestess and the performance of cleansing rites and sacrifices further demonstrate the community's confidence in indigenous religious institutions, while Grandma Owei's participation in the prescribed sacrifices reflects her commitment to traditional spirituality. These ritual activities are illustrated in Plate 1.



Plate1: Grandma Owei performing the cleansing and sacrificial rites after Ebi-Ere's violation of the sacred river.

Culled from *Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches* byEgbuson Queen Ebikonboere on 06/26/2026.

The film also presents Christianity alongside African traditional religion through the character of Douye. Although he consistently prays and seeks divine intervention as a Christian, he neither ridicules nor rejects the traditional beliefs of his community. This coexistence reflects the religious reality of many Niger Delta communities, where Christianity and indigenous religion continue to exist side by side.

Respect for Sacred Customs and Taboos

Respect for sacred customs and taboos constitutes another important cultural element in the film. The prohibition against women visiting the sacred river during menstruation is treated as a communal law rather than an individual choice. Every member of the community recognises the importance of the regulation and the consequences attached to its violation. Before Ebi-Ere

enters the river, she receives repeated warnings, including advice from Shade. Ebi-Ere's deliberate disregard for these warnings leads to the tragedy that follows. As illustrated in Plate 2, the scene emphasises the sacredness of indigenous laws and their role in maintaining social and spiritual order.



Plate2:Ebi-Ere in the sacred river despite repeated warnings.

Culled from *Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches* byEgbuson Queen Ebikonboere on 06/26/2026.

Family and Kinship System

The film emphasises the importance of family relationships within Ijaw society. Despite Ebi-Ere's prolonged absence, Grandma Owei persistently invites her granddaughter to return home, demonstrating the enduring bond between grandparents and grandchildren. Likewise, Douye's parents actively guide the relationship between Douye and Ebi-Ere by educating them on the customs governing traditional marriage. Rather than viewing marriage as a private affair, the film portrays it as a union involving families and the wider community. This emphasis on kinship and communal responsibility is illustrated in Plate 3.



Plate 3: Grandma Owei welcoming Ebi-Ere, Douye, and others to Okoloba, illustrating the strength of family ties in African society.

Culled from *Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches* byEgbuson Queen Ebikonboere on 06/26/2026.

Traditional Marriage Institution

Marriage is presented as an important cultural institution in *Stitches*. As Douye and Ebi-Ere's relationship develops, community elders encourage them to undertake the appropriate traditional marriage process. Their guidance extends beyond romantic affection to include responsibility, family participation, and adherence to customary procedures. The elders' involvement demonstrates that marriage is regarded as a communal institution governed by established cultural norms. This process is depicted in Plate 4.



Plate4:Douye parents' discussion on how Ebi-ere should be traditionally married to him.

Culled from *Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches* byEgbuson Queen Ebikonboere on 06/26/2026.

Communal Life and Collective Responsibility

One of the defining characteristics of Okoloba society is its strong communal orientation. Individual experiences are treated as collective concerns, and community members actively participate in one another's lives. This communal philosophy is particularly evident after Ebi-Ere falls critically ill. Her condition becomes a concern for the entire community as elders, family members, the Chief Priestess, and other villagers collectively seek solutions to restore her health. This communal solidarity is illustrated in Plate 5.



Plate 5: Members of the Okoloba community gathered in concern over Ebi-Ere's condition, demonstrating communal responsibility and solidarity.

Culled from *Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches* byEgbuson Queen Ebikonboere on 06/26/2026.

Indigenous Festivals and Cultural Celebrations

The annual cultural festival represents one of the film's most visible expressions of indigenous culture. Beyond entertainment, it provides an avenue for celebrating heritage, strengthening social relationships, and transmitting cultural values across generations. Through communal participation, visitors such as Ebi-Ere and Shade experience the richness of Okoloba's traditions firsthand. Festival activities, including communal celebrations, traditional dances, and wrestling competitions, are presented in Plates 6–8.



Plate 6: Villagers participating in the annual cultural festival in Okoloba, showcasing communal celebration.

Culled from *Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches* byEgbuson Queen Ebikonboere on 06/26/2026.



Plate 7:cultural dance performances in the annual cultural festival in Okoloba, showcasing indigenous music, dance, and communal celebration.

Culled from *Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches* byEgbuson Queen Ebikonboere on 06/26/2026.

Indigenous Language as Cultural Identity

Language functions as another important marker of cultural identity in *Stitches*. The film combines English with the Ijaw language to reflect the multilingual reality of Bayelsa State. While English dominates conversations among the younger characters, Ijaw is predominantly spoken by Grandma Owei, Douye's parents, the Chief Priestess, and other members of the Okoloba community. Its use during family discussions, communal meetings, traditional ceremonies, and sacred rituals strengthens the authenticity of the narrative while preserving indigenous linguistic heritage.

Respect for Elders and Traditional Authority

Respect for elders and traditional authority is consistently portrayed throughout the film. Elders function as custodians of communal values, providing guidance on marriage, cultural practices, and conflict resolution. Likewise, the Chief Priestess occupies an important position as the custodian of the community's spiritual traditions. Grandma Owei further exemplifies the respected status of elderly women through their commitment to preserving indigenous values.

Cultural Landscape and Riverine Environment

The riverine landscape of Okoloba constitutes another important cultural element. Traditional homes, communal spaces, and the sacred river collectively reflect the geographical realities of the Niger Delta. The sacred river functions simultaneously as a geographical location, a spiritual symbol, and the focal point of the film's central conflict. This cultural landscape is presented in Plate 8.



Plate 8: The riverine landscape of Okoloba, illustrating the cultural and geographical identity of the Ijaw community.

Culled from *Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's Stitches* by Egbuson Queen Ebikonboere on 06/26/2026.

Stitches effectively projects the cultural heritage of the Ijaw people by integrating indigenous

religion, sacred taboos, communal living, family values, traditional marriage, festivals, language, respect for elders, and the riverine environment into its narrative. Through these cultural elements, Jide JBlaze Oyegbile presents a film that not only entertains but also documents and preserves important aspects of Niger Delta cultural identity while affirming the continuing relevance of indigenous traditions in contemporary African society.

Traditions, Values and Identity of the Ijaw People in Jide Jblaze Oyegbile's *Stitches*

Stitches presents a compelling depiction of the traditions, values, and cultural identity of the Ijaw people through the fictional community of Okoloba. Rather than using culture merely as a background for storytelling, the film places indigenous traditions at the centre of its narrative, allowing them to shape characters' actions, conflicts, and the outcome of the story. Through its representation of customs, language, family relationships, religious practices, communal life, and moral expectations, the film portrays Ijaw cultural identity as a dynamic system that continues to influence contemporary society.

One of the most visible aspects of Ijaw identity presented in the film is the people's strong attachment to their ancestral traditions. Okoloba is portrayed as a community where customs regulate individual behaviour and promote social harmony. The sacred prohibition against women entering the sacred river during menstruation demonstrates the reverence attached to traditional laws and the belief that violating them attracts spiritual consequences. Ebi-Ere's deliberate violation of this communal tradition becomes the central conflict of the narrative and ultimately leads to the tragic events that follow. As illustrated in Plate 2, the incident emphasizes the importance the Ijaw people place on obedience to established cultural norms and ancestral practices.

The film equally projects the Ijaw value of respect for elders and traditional authority. Elders occupy positions of honour within the community and serve as custodians of indigenous knowledge and moral values. Characters such as Grandma Owei, Douye's parents, and the Chief Priestess provide guidance on family life, marriage, spirituality, and conflict resolution. Their opinions command respect, while their decisions carry communal authority. As shown in Plate 1, the Chief Priestess and Grandma Owei perform the prescribed cleansing rites after the violation of the sacred taboo, illustrating the authority of traditional institutions.

Family solidarity and communal responsibility are equally prominent. Grandma Owei's persistent efforts to reunite with Ebi-Ere demonstrate the importance of kinship ties. Likewise, after Ebi-Ere falls critically ill, her condition becomes the concern of the entire community. The collective involvement of Grandma Owei, Douye's parents, the Chief Priestess, and other villagers reflects the communal philosophy that the welfare of one individual affects the wellbeing of the entire society. This communal bond is evident in Plates 3 and 5.

The institution of traditional marriage also reflects an important aspect of Ijaw identity. As Douye and Ebi-Ere's relationship develops, the elders encourage them to follow the accepted marriage customs of the community. Marriage is portrayed not merely as a personal relationship but as an institution involving family participation, communal approval, and adherence to customary procedures. The discussion by Douye's parents, illustrated in Plate 4, demonstrates the significance attached to traditional marriage rites.

Language equally functions as a significant marker of Ijaw identity. While English is spoken mainly by the younger generation, the Ijaw language dominates communication among Grandma Owei, Douye's parents, the Chief Priestess, and other members of the community. Its use during family interactions, communal meetings, traditional ceremonies, and spiritual rituals reinforces the indigenous identity of Okoloba while preserving cultural heritage and transmitting indigenous knowledge.

The film further highlights the close relationship between the Ijaw people and their natural environment. The riverine setting of Okoloba is more than a physical location; it is an essential component of the community's cultural identity. Rivers, forests, and sacred spaces possess ecological and spiritual significance, with the sacred river serving as the central cultural symbol around which the narrative revolves. As depicted in Plate 9, the riverine landscape illustrates the inseparable relationship between the people, their environment, and their cultural worldview.

Cultural festivals equally contribute to the projection of Ijaw identity. The annual cultural festival provides a platform for communal celebration, cultural expression, and the transmission of indigenous traditions through music, dance, traditional attire, and wrestling competitions. The festival scenes in Plates 6, 7, and 8 demonstrate how indigenous celebrations preserve cultural memory and reinforce communal identity.

Finally, *Stitches* presents cultural identity as a continuous negotiation between tradition and modernity. Ebi-Ere initially rejects the beliefs and customs of her ancestral community, whereas Douye reconciles his Christian faith with respect for indigenous traditions, and Shade exemplifies cultural tolerance. Through these contrasting perspectives, the film suggests that cultural identity remains relevant in shaping personal values, morality, and communal life despite modernization.

Overall, *Stitches* successfully projects the traditions, values, and identity of the Ijaw people through its representation of indigenous religion, respect for elders, communal living, family solidarity, traditional marriage, language, festivals, and the riverine environment. By integrating these cultural elements into its narrative, the film serves not only as entertainment but also as an important cultural document that preserves and promotes the heritage of the Ijaw people.

Role of *Stitches* in the Promotion, Preservation, and Transmission Of Ijaw Culture

Stitches functions as both a cinematic narrative and a cultural medium for the promotion, preservation, and transmission of Ijaw culture. Through its representation of traditional institutions, communal relationships, indigenous spirituality, language, festivals, marriage customs, and the riverine environment of Okoloba, the film projects the richness of Ijaw cultural heritage while preserving important aspects of the people's identity and worldview. Rather than presenting culture merely as a backdrop for entertainment, the film integrates indigenous practices into its narrative, making them central to the characters' decisions and the resolution of the story. The film promotes and preserves indigenous religious beliefs through its portrayal of the sacred river and the spiritual laws governing the community. The prohibition against women visiting the river during menstruation reflects established indigenous regulations intended to maintain spiritual harmony. Ebi-Ere's deliberate violation of this cultural taboo and the

consequences that follow illustrate the seriousness with which the community regards its traditional beliefs. Likewise, the consultation of the Chief Priestess and the performance of cleansing rites and sacrifices, shown in Plate 1, document important aspects of Ijaw indigenous spirituality while reinforcing their cultural significance.

The institution of traditional authority is equally promoted through the portrayal of elders as custodians of communal values and indigenous knowledge. Grandma Owei, Douye's parents, and the Chief Priestess provide moral guidance, resolve conflicts, preserve customs, and ensure that established traditions are respected. Their influence over matters relating to marriage, spirituality, and communal welfare highlights the continuing relevance of traditional leadership institutions. Traditional marriage customs are similarly promoted through the narrative. As Douye and Ebi-Ere's relationship develops, members of the community encourage them to observe the accepted marriage rites of Okoloba. The guidance offered by Douye's parents, illustrated in Plate 4, demonstrates that marriage extends beyond personal affection to include family participation, communal approval, and adherence to customary procedures.

The film also promotes the communal philosophy that characterizes traditional Ijaw society. Individual experiences become collective concerns, particularly after Ebi-Ere falls critically ill. Grandma Owei, Douye, his parents, the Chief Priestess, and other members of the community collectively seek solutions to restore her health. This spirit of collective responsibility, illustrated in Plate 5, reflects the Ijaw principle that community members share responsibility for one another's wellbeing. Language remains one of the strongest vehicles for cultural promotion and preservation in the film. The consistent use of the Ijaw language during family discussions, communal deliberations, traditional ceremonies, and sacred rituals projects indigenous expressions while safeguarding traditional modes of communication. Although English is spoken by some younger characters, the prominence of the Ijaw language contributes significantly to preserving the community's linguistic heritage.

The film further promotes Ijaw culture through its depiction of festivals and communal celebrations. The annual cultural festival, presented in Plates 6, 7, and 8, showcases traditional music, dance, wrestling, indigenous attire, and communal participation. These cultural performances celebrate the richness of Ijaw heritage while strengthening communal identity and encouraging younger generations to embrace their cultural roots. Similarly, the riverine landscape of Okoloba plays an important role in promoting Ijaw culture. The rivers, traditional homesteads, sacred spaces, and natural environment are portrayed as cultural landscapes that shape the beliefs, occupations, and everyday experiences of the people. The sacred river and surrounding environment, illustrated in Plate 9, reinforce the relationship between place, culture, and identity.

Finally, *Stitches* demonstrates that indigenous cultural practices remain relevant despite modernization. Through the contrasting perspectives of Ebi-Ere, Douye, and Shade, the film explores the relationship between contemporary lifestyles and traditional values. While Ebi-Ere initially rejects her ancestral customs, Douye harmonizes Christian faith with indigenous traditions, and Shade exemplifies cultural tolerance and respect.

Overall, *Stitches* serves as an effective medium for the promotion, preservation, and transmission of Ijaw culture. Through its representation of indigenous religion, communal life,

traditional authority, marriage customs, language, festivals, family values, and the riverine environment, the film celebrates the richness of Ijaw cultural heritage while safeguarding it for future generations. Consequently, the film functions not only as entertainment but also as a cultural archive that promotes cultural awareness, preserves indigenous knowledge, strengthens cultural identity, and facilitates the transmission of Ijaw traditions and values across generations.

RECOMMENDATIONS

Based on the findings of this study, the following recommendations are made:

- i. Government agencies, cultural institutions, and development partners should establish funding schemes to support the production, promotion, documentation, and distribution of indigenous-language films that showcase Ijaw cultural heritage.
- ii. Stronger intellectual property protection and effective anti-piracy measures should be implemented to safeguard filmmakers' investments, improve revenue generation, and encourage the production of culturally oriented films.
- iii. Film schools, workshops, and capacity-building programmes should integrate indigenous cultural studies with technical filmmaking skills to equip filmmakers to produce culturally authentic and globally competitive films.
- iv. Partnerships among government agencies, private investors, traditional institutions, cultural organisations, and filmmakers should be strengthened to promote the production, exhibition, and preservation of indigenous films through cultural festivals, educational programmes, and community initiatives.
- v. Indigenous Ijaw films should be distributed through international film festivals, digital streaming platforms, television networks, and other online media to increase global visibility, promote appreciation of Ijaw culture, and preserve the community's cultural heritage.

CONCLUSION

This study examined the promotion and preservation of Ijaw culture through Jide JBlaze Oyegbile's *Stitches*. The findings show that the film serves as a cultural text by representing Ijaw language, spirituality, marriage customs, music, costumes, festivals, traditional authority, and communal values. Through these elements, *Stitches* reinforces Ijaw cultural identity and demonstrates the role of indigenous cinema in preserving cultural heritage. Using Stuart Hall's Representation Theory and Edward B. Tylor's Cultural Transmission Theory, the study argues that the film contributes to African indigenous cinema by showing how visual storytelling represents and transmits cultural knowledge. By focusing on an Ijaw-language film, it extends scholarship beyond mainstream Nollywood and highlights the importance of minority-language cinema in cultural preservation.

The study also identifies challenges facing indigenous filmmaking, including inadequate funding, piracy, weak distribution, and limited institutional support. Since the analysis is limited to *Stitches*, future studies should examine audience reception, compare other indigenous-language films, and explore how cinematic techniques shape cultural representation. Overall, *Stitches* affirms that indigenous film remains an effective medium for promoting and preserving Ijaw cultural heritage.

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